

General IT English

Participant workbook: service language, infrastructure discussion, security risk, incident updates, and IT workplace practice

Audience: advanced ESL learners working in IT operations, support, infrastructure, cloud, security, or adjacent roles

Focus: high-level professional English for general IT teams, including service management, networks, identity, cloud, endpoints, security operations, change control, observability, and realistic workplace dialogue.

Designed for advanced ESL learners who already work in IT or IT-adjacent roles and need field-specific fluency rather than basic technical vocabulary.

Teaching stance: general IT is not one job. Learners need enough shared language to move across help desk, infrastructure, security, cloud, platform, vendor, and business conversations without losing precision or credibility.

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook helps you sound precise and credible in general IT conversations. The goal is not to use more jargon. The goal is to use the right term, ask better questions, explain risk calmly, and write updates that help people act.

Your starting point

- Which conversations are hardest for you: user calls, incident bridges, access reviews, change meetings, security escalations, vendor calls, or executive updates?
- Which IT terms do you understand when reading but avoid when speaking?
- When someone pressures you for a risky shortcut, do you become too indirect, too blunt, or too technical?
- What is one recent ticket or incident you wish you had explained more clearly?

Use the guided dialogue activities below. Every item has four choices and a rationale in the answer key; no open-ended writing is required.

IT Stack Language

Layer	Useful verbs	Example sentence
User/device	report, reproduce, capture, reset, verify	The user can reproduce the issue only on the managed laptop.
Network	resolve, route, block, allow, tunnel, inspect	DNS resolves to the old address for some remote users.
Identity	authenticate, authorize, grant, revoke, audit	Authentication succeeded, but authorization failed because the user lacks the role.
Server/cloud	provision, scale, patch, snapshot, restore	The instance scaled up, but the storage volume is near saturation.
Application	deploy, roll back, validate, monitor, log	The application is healthy, but the load balancer health check is failing.
Security	detect, contain, investigate, remediate, report	We contained the account compromise and are reviewing sign-in logs.

Practice Pages

Module 1. IT Service Language, Tickets, and Triage

General IT work often starts with incomplete reports: 'VPN is broken,' 'the app is slow,' or 'users cannot log in.' Strong IT English turns vague pain into scope, impact, evidence, priority, and next action.

What you should be able to do

- Distinguish incident, service request, problem, change, task, and known error.
- Ask triage questions about impact, urgency, affected users, timeline, and recent changes.
- Write ticket updates that are useful to both technical teams and business stakeholders.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A remote employee reports that the VPN connects, but the finance system will not load.

Speaker	Line
User	The VPN is broken again. I cannot get to finance.
Service desk	I understand the impact. Can I confirm one detail: does the VPN show connected, or does the connection fail completely?
User	It says connected.
ESL learner	Then we should avoid calling this a VPN outage yet. It may be DNS, routing, firewall, or the finance app itself. Are other internal sites loading?
User	The intranet loads, but finance times out.
ESL learner	Thank you. I will update the ticket as 'VPN connected; finance app unreachable over VPN for one user.' I am checking whether this is user-specific or app-wide before _____.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	mitigation
B	approval
C	escalating
D	assumption

Module 2. Networks, Connectivity, and Root-Cause Hypotheses

Network conversations require careful hypothesis language. DNS, DHCP, VPN, routing, firewall rules, certificates, proxies, and load balancers can create similar user symptoms.

What you should be able to do

- Explain common network components and failure modes in workplace English.
- Separate user-side, device-side, network-side, and application-side evidence.
- Use cautious root-cause language before proof is available.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

Multiple users cannot reach a customer portal after a DNS change.

Speaker	Line
Incident commander	We need a clear status. Is the portal down?
Network engineer	The application servers are healthy. DNS queries are returning the old address for some users.
ESL learner	So the service is partially unavailable because name resolution is inconsistent after the change. The immediate mitigation is to roll back the DNS record and lower the TTL if possible.
App owner	Can we say the application is not the cause?
ESL learner	We can say current _____ points to DNS propagation, not application health. We should avoid final root-cause language until we review the change timeline and resolver logs.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	scope
B	evidence
C	risk
D	owner

Module 3. Identity, Access, and Permissions

Access requests are rarely just technical. They involve identity proof, authorization, least privilege, auditability, urgency, and sometimes uncomfortable pushback to senior people.

What you should be able to do

- Distinguish authentication, authorization, SSO, MFA, RBAC, groups, roles, and service accounts.
- Explain least privilege and conditional access without sounding obstructive.
- Handle urgent access requests with controls, time limits, approvals, and audit trails.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A senior manager asks for admin rights to fix a reporting dashboard before a board meeting.

Speaker	Line
Manager	Just give me admin access for today. I know what I am doing.
IT lead	We want to help with the deadline, but permanent admin rights are not the right control.
ESL learner	We can offer a time-limited privileged session with approval, logging, and a clear task scope. After the task, access will be removed automatically.
Manager	That sounds slow.
ESL learner	It is faster than a normal access change, but it still protects the company and your account. I can start the exception workflow now and stay with you until the _____ is fixed.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	risk
B	owner
C	dashboard
D	evidence

Module 4. Cloud, Infrastructure, and Cost-Aware Operations

Cloud IT conversations combine architecture, operations, cost, security, and ownership. Learners need to discuss tradeoffs without treating cloud as unlimited or invisible.

What you should be able to do

- Use terms such as region, availability zone, VPC, subnet, VM, storage, snapshot, autoscaling, IaC, tagging, and shared responsibility.
- Explain reliability, performance, security, sustainability, and cost tradeoffs.
- Discuss unexpected cloud spend with evidence and practical mitigation options.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

Security wants to patch a critical vulnerability; operations worries about downtime during month-end close.

Speaker	Line
Security	This CVE is being actively exploited. We need the patch tonight.
Operations	Tonight is month-end close. If the ERP system is down, finance cannot finish.
ESL learner	We have two risks: exploitation if we wait, and business disruption if the patch fails. Can we test the patch in staging now, apply compensating controls tonight, and schedule production for the first safe window?
Security	What controls?
ESL learner	Restrict exposure, increase monitoring, block known indicators, and require rollback approval before any production change. If exploitation _____ appears, we move to emergency change.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	mitigation
B	approval
C	evidence
D	assumption

Module 5. Endpoints, Servers, Patching, and Configuration Management

Endpoint and server operations require clear language about assets, baselines, patches, compatibility, exceptions, maintenance windows, rollback, and user disruption.

What you should be able to do

- Discuss patching and configuration risk with technical and business audiences.
- Explain asset inventory, MDM, EDR, encryption, baseline configuration, and policy compliance.
- Negotiate maintenance windows and exception requests.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

Finance notices a 38 percent increase in monthly cloud spend.

Speaker	Line
Finance	Why did cloud cost jump? Did IT approve this?
Cloud engineer	Most of the increase is compute in the analytics environment and log retention in production.
ESL learner	The immediate issue is spend, but the operational issue is ownership. Several resources have no cost-center tags, so we cannot assign accountability confidently.
Finance	Can you cut it today?
ESL learner	We can stop idle non-production instances today, reduce excessive log retention where policy allows, and bring a tagging enforcement plan by Friday. I would not delete storage until owners _____ retention requirements.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	control
B	disclosure
C	evidence
D	confirm

Module 6. Security Operations, Risk, and Incident Response

Security conversations require precision and restraint. Vulnerability, exploit, alert, event, incident, risk, compromise, and breach are not interchangeable words.

What you should be able to do

- Use security operations vocabulary accurately in alerts, tickets, escalations, and briefings.
- Explain risk using likelihood, impact, exposure, compensating controls, and evidence.
- Participate in incident response without creating panic or hiding uncertainty.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A containerized internal tool fails after a deployment.

Speaker	Line
Developer	The deployment is broken. The pods keep restarting.
Platform engineer	The readiness probe is failing, and the logs show missing environment variables.
ESL learner	Then the cluster is doing what it should: it is not sending traffic to unhealthy pods. The likely cause is release configuration, not Kubernetes itself.
Developer	Should we roll back?
ESL learner	Yes, unless there is a faster config fix with lower _____. My recommendation is rollback now, restore service, then compare the deployment manifest with the previous version.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	evidence
B	owner
C	risk
D	disclosure

Module 7. Change, Release, Problem, and Post-Incident Communication

Mature IT teams separate fixing the current outage from understanding recurring causes. Learners need language for change records, CAB review, maintenance windows, rollback, problem management, root cause, and action items.

What you should be able to do

- Discuss normal, standard, emergency, and high-risk changes.
- Explain root cause, contributing factors, detection gaps, and corrective actions without blame.
- Write action items that have owners, due dates, and verification criteria.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A user clicked a suspicious link and entered credentials.

Speaker	Line
User	I think I made a mistake. I entered my password on a weird page.
Service desk	Thank you for reporting quickly. Please do not change anything else yet.
ESL learner	We will reset your password, revoke active sessions, check sign-in logs, and confirm whether MFA prompts were accepted. Can you forward the email as an attachment to security?
User	Am I in trouble?
ESL learner	The priority is containment and _____. Reporting quickly helps us protect your account and other users.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	control
B	disclosure
C	risk
D	evidence

Module 8. Platform, DevOps, Observability, and Kubernetes Conversations

Even general IT staff increasingly discuss CI/CD, containers, Kubernetes, logs, metrics, traces, SLOs, and automation. Learners need enough language to participate without pretending to be specialists.

What you should be able to do

- Explain containers, images, registries, pods, deployments, services, ingress, and rollout behavior.
- Use observability terms: logs, metrics, traces, dashboards, alerts, latency, throughput, saturation, and error budget.
- Connect platform symptoms to business impact and incident decisions.

Guided dialogue completion

Situation

A restore test shows that the system can recover, but with more data loss than expected.

Speaker	Line
Business owner	The restore worked, so are we good?
Database admin	The restore completed, but the latest usable backup is six hours old.
ESL learner	That means the RTO may be acceptable, but the RPO is not. We can restore service in time, but we may lose more data than the business agreed to.
Business owner	I did not understand that difference.
ESL learner	RTO is how long recovery takes. RPO is how much data loss is acceptable. We need either more frequent backups, replication, or a formal acceptance of the higher data-loss _____.

Choose the missing language

Option	Phrase
A	owner
B	scope
C	risk
D	evidence

Phrase Bank

Triage and scope

- Can we separate user impact from component health?
- How many users, which locations, and which business process are affected?
- What changed recently: deployment, configuration, certificate, DNS, firewall, identity policy, or vendor status?
- Do we have logs, timestamps, screenshots, error messages, and a reproducible path?

Cautious root-cause language

- Current evidence points to DNS, but we have not confirmed root cause yet.
- This appears to be a configuration issue rather than a platform outage.
- We have restored service; the contributing factors are still under review.
- I would avoid saying 'breach' until security confirms unauthorized access or data exposure.

Pushback and risk

- I understand the urgency, but broad admin access is not the right control.
- The shortcut reduces delivery risk today but increases security and audit risk.
- Can we approve a time-limited exception with monitoring and an expiration date?
- Before we make this change, we need a rollback plan and a communication owner.

Incident bridge language

- The immediate goal is service restoration; root-cause analysis comes after stabilization.
- The mitigation is in progress, and the next checkpoint is in 15 minutes.
- We need one owner for customer communication and one owner for technical recovery.
- Please post only confirmed facts in the incident channel; hypotheses should be labeled as hypotheses.

Security and identity

- Authentication succeeded, but authorization failed because the user lacks the required role.
- Least privilege protects the user, the system, and the audit trail.
- We should revoke sessions, reset credentials, and review sign-in logs before closing the incident.
- A vulnerability is confirmed, but we do not yet have evidence of exploitation.

Business-facing explanations

- RTO is how long recovery takes; RPO is how much data loss the business can tolerate.
- The application is healthy, but users cannot reach it because name resolution is inconsistent.
- The cost increase is mostly idle compute and longer log retention, not user growth.
- The change is technically simple, but the blast radius is large if it fails.

Answer Key and Rationale

Check each answer after completing the dialogue. The rationale shows why the correct phrase is the strongest fit for the real workplace situation.

1. Service Desk Escalation: 'VPN Is Broken'

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. escalating	'escalating' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

2. P1 Incident Bridge: DNS or Application Outage?

Correct answer	Why it fits
B. evidence	'evidence' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

3. Access Review: Urgent Admin Permission

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. dashboard	'dashboard' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

4. Patch Window Negotiation

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. evidence	'evidence' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

5. Cloud Cost Spike

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. confirm	'confirm' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

6. Kubernetes Incident: Crashing Pods

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. risk	'risk' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

7. Phishing and Possible Account Compromise

Correct answer	Why it fits
D. evidence	'evidence' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.

8. Backup Restore Test: RPO Mismatch

Correct answer	Why it fits
C. risk	'risk' is the precise phrase used in this professional response. The other choices do not fit the dialogue's meaning or grammar.